

He supplemented his training in harmony and counterpoint with lessons learned during visits to the vast San Carlo Theater in Naples to hear works by Rossini, Mayr, Donizetti, Mercadante, and Spontini. He crowned his studies with his opera *Adelson e Salvini* (1825), which led to a commission for San Carlo: *Bianca e Fernando*, first performed in May 1826. This launched the composer's professional career. The following April, Bellini moved north to Milan to work at the Teatro alla Scala, which was one of Italy's finest opera houses. His first work for La Scala, *Il pirata* (1827), was a triumph and was promptly staged in Naples and Vienna. Opera was the most lucrative outlet for the work of Italian composers in the early 1800s. The peninsula's assorted kingdoms and city-states supported a great network of opera houses, each serving audiences that were hungry for new pieces.



TEATRO DI SAN CARLO

The spectacular interior of the San Carlo Theater in Naples—where Bellini's *Bianca e Fernando* premiered in 1826, launching his career—is represented in this work, c. 1830, by Cetto de Stefano. The San Carlo is Europe's oldest opera house.